Learn French for Beginners

Le Mauvais Colis

A story in 20 episodes · A1–B1

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The Wrong Parcel

A 20-episode romcom in Belleville: two neighbours called Garnier keep getting each other's parcels, and the wrong door slowly turns out to be the right one. On the sixth floor of an old building in Belleville, two doors face each other, and behind both lives someone called Garnier. Zoé, a drummer from Marseille, goes to bed at two in the morning; Gabriel, who repairs antique music boxes, goes to bed at half past nine. The delivery rider never knows which door is which, so their parcels always arrive at the wrong one. Notes turn into arguments, arguments into a truce, and the truce into Saturday dinners. Each episode ends with L'expression du jour, an everyday expression from the dialogue to learn and reuse.

How to read

Each line gives the speaker and the French, then the English in italics. The respellings (English-style pronunciation, not IPA) are only in the word list at the end of each episode; ‿ marks a liaison there (*vous avez* = voo‿zah-vay). The questions for every episode and the answer key are at the end. The word in brackets after the English, such as *(teasing)*, says how the line is said.

Spelling	Sounds like
zh	the "s" in *measure* (French **j** / soft **g**)
uh	the "a" in *about*
ew	French **u**: say "ee" with your lips rounded like "oo"
N (capital)	nasal vowel: hum the vowel through your nose, don't say the "n"
ahN	nasal *an* / *en* (as in *France*)
ohN	nasal *on* (as in *bon*)
aN	nasal *in* / *ain* / *ien* (as in *vin*)
uhN	nasal *un* (as in *un*)
r	French throaty "r", made at the back of the throat
‿	liaison: the silent final consonant is pronounced at the start of the next word (*vous‿avez* = voo zah-vay)

The people

Gabriel, music-box repairer (episodes 1, 2, 3, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20)

Zoé, drummer (episodes 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 10, 11, 12, 13, 15, 16, 18, 19, 20)

Yanis, delivery rider (episodes 4, 13)

Fatou, concierge (episodes 9, 17)

Hélène, Gabriel's sister (episode 14)

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Act 1 · La mauvaise porte (The wrong door)

Level A1

Episode 1 · Le colis (The parcel)

On Monday at a quarter past nine in the evening, Gabriel, in his buttoned navy cardigan and slippers, carries a huge round parcel across the sixth-floor landing in Belleville to the apple-green door, where drums are booming. Zoé opens with soil on her hands, fairy lights and plants behind her. When they say good night, both doors open again at the same moment, and the music behind the green door is a little softer.

Gabriel Bonsoir, madame. Je crois que c'est à vous.
Good evening. I think this is yours. (annoyed)

Zoé Mon tambour ! Enfin ! Merci, voisin !
My drum! At last! Thanks, neighbour! (surprised)

Gabriel Il est très lourd. Et il fait « boum ».
It's very heavy. And it goes "boom". (neutral)

Zoé Normal, monsieur. C'est mon tambour.
Of course it does, sir. It's my drum. (amused)

Gabriel Votre musique… Il est neuf heures du soir.
Your music… It's nine o'clock at night. (annoyed)

Zoé Et alors ? Neuf heures, c'est tôt !
So what? Nine o'clock is early! (teasing)

Gabriel Moi, je me couche à neuf heures et demie.
I go to bed at half past nine. (neutral)

Zoé Moi, je me couche à deux heures du matin !
I go to bed at two in the morning! (surprised)

Gabriel Et je me lève à six heures. Tous les jours.
And I get up at six. Every day. (proud)

Zoé On est comme le jour et la nuit, voisin.
We're like night and day, neighbour. (amused)

Gabriel Bonne nuit, madame… ? Moi, c'est Gabriel Garnier.
Good night, Ms…? I'm Gabriel Garnier. (curious)

Zoé Garnier ? Moi aussi ! Zoé Garnier !
Garnier? Me too! Zoé Garnier! (surprised)

Words from this episode

- **je me couche** *(zhuh muh koosh)* — I go to bed
- **je me lève** *(zhuh muh lev)* — I get up
- **Je crois que** *(zhuh krwah kuh)* — I think that
- **Bonsoir** *(bohN-swahr)* — Good evening
- **Bonne nuit** *(bun nwee)* — Good night
- **neuf heures et demie** *(nuh‿vuhr ay duh-mee)* — half past nine
- **deux heures du matin** *(duh‿zuhr dew mah-taN)* — two in the morning
- **comme le jour et la nuit** *(kum luh zhoor ay lah nwee)* — like night and day
- **voisin** *(vwah-zaN)* — neighbour

Notice: Reflexive verbs: je me couche

Gabriel says « Je me couche à neuf heures et demie » and « je me lève à six heures ». Reflexive verbs have an extra pronoun that matches the subject: je me, tu te, il or elle se, vous vous. You already know one: « je m'appelle » (me becomes m' before a vowel).

See the table: Grammar tables, Reflexive pronouns.

Episode 2 · Le petit mot (The note)

On Tuesday at half past seven in the morning, Zoé, hair wild after three hours of sleep, knocks on the navy door holding a tiny brown-paper parcel and a folded white card. Gabriel opens, dressed and shaved, his blue-band mug of tea in hand. They argue on the landing, haggle like at a market, and seal the deal with a stiff handshake.

Zoé Bonjour, monsieur Garnier. Votre petit colis. Et votre petit mot.
Good morning, Mr Garnier. Your little parcel. And your little note. (annoyed)

Gabriel Merci, madame. Vous êtes debout à sept heures et demie ?
Thank you. You're up at half past seven? (surprised)

Zoé Non. Je ne suis pas debout. Je suis en colère.
No. I'm not up. I'm angry. (annoyed)

Zoé « Madame, le soir, la musique est trop forte. Merci. »
"Madam, in the evening the music is too loud. Thank you." (teasing)

Gabriel C'est vrai. Je ne dors pas. Je ne travaille pas.
It's true. I can't sleep. I can't work. (neutral)

Zoé La musique, c'est la vie, monsieur !
Music is life, sir! (proud)

Gabriel Le silence aussi, madame.
So is silence, madam. (teasing)

Gabriel Votre tambour, le soir, ça casse les oreilles.
Your drum, in the evening, is deafening. (annoyed)

Gabriel Alors… pas de musique après dix heures ?
So… no music after ten o'clock? (curious)

Zoé Onze heures.
Eleven. (teasing)

Gabriel Dix heures et demie ?
Half past ten? (neutral)

Zoé Marché conclu ! Dix heures et demie. Pas une minute avant !
Deal! Half past ten. Not a minute before! (proud)

Words from this episode

- **Bonjour** *(bohN-zhoor)* — Hello / Good morning
- **petit mot** *(puh-tee moh)* — little note
- **Je ne suis pas debout** *(zhuh nuh swee pah duh-boo)* — I'm not up
- **Je suis en colère** *(zhuh swee ahN koh-lair)* — I'm angry
- **Je ne dors pas** *(zhuh nuh dor pah)* — I can't sleep / I don't sleep
- **Je ne travaille pas** *(zhuh nuh trah-vahy pah)* — I can't work / I don't work
- **ça casse les oreilles** *(sah kahs lay‿zoh-rey)* — it's deafening (it breaks your ears)
- **pas de musique** *(pah duh mew-zeek)* — no music
- **Dix heures et demie** *(dee‿zuhr ay duh-mee)* — half past ten

Notice: Saying no: ne… pas

Zoé says « Je ne suis pas debout » and Gabriel answers « Je ne dors pas. Je ne travaille pas. » The negative wraps the verb: ne before it, pas after it. After a negative, a noun takes just de: « pas de musique ».

See the table: Grammar tables, Negative words.

Episode 3 · La guerre des petits mots (The war of notes)

On Saturday at twenty to midnight, the two doors of the landing are covered: plain white folded cards on Zoé's green door, crooked yellow squares on Gabriel's navy one. Both doors open at the same moment, Gabriel holding a white card, Zoé a yellow square. Caught, they argue about red-pen corrections, then laugh for the first time, and in the middle of the landing they swap their notes by hand.

Gabriel Ah. Bonsoir, madame.
Oh. Good evening, madam. (surprised)

Zoé Encore vous ! Vous aussi, vous avez un petit mot ?
You again! You've got a note too? (surprised)

Zoé Vous corrigez mes fautes ? En rouge ?
You correct my spelling mistakes? In red? (annoyed)

Gabriel Il y a trois fautes. Dans six mots.
There are three mistakes. In six words. (proud)

Zoé Et vous, vous écrivez « merci » partout. C'est bizarre.
And you write "thank you" everywhere. It's weird. (teasing)

Gabriel Votre tambour, ce soir : onze heures moins le quart.
Your drum, tonight: a quarter to eleven. (annoyed)

Zoé Quinze minutes ! Vous êtes une horloge, monsieur ?
Fifteen minutes! Are you a clock, sir? (amused)

Gabriel Un peu. C'est mon métier.
A little. It's my job. (teasing)

Zoé Vous et moi, on est comme chien et chat.
You and I fight like cat and dog. (amused)

Gabriel Ah bon ? Et qui est le chien ?
Really? And who's the dog? (curious)

Zoé Vous ! Vous grognez tout le temps.
You! You growl all the time. (teasing)

Gabriel Bon. Je prends votre mot. Vous prenez mon mot ?
Fine. I'll take your note. Will you take mine? (amused)

Words from this episode

- **Bonsoir** *(bohN-swahr)* — Good evening
- **Encore vous** *(ahN-kor voo)* — You again
- **vous avez** *(voo‿zah-vay)* — you have
- **mes fautes** *(may foht)* — my mistakes
- **Il y a trois fautes** *(eel ee ah trwah foht)* — There are three mistakes
- **vous écrivez** *(voo‿zay-kree-vay)* — you write
- **onze heures moins le quart** *(ohN-zuhr mwaN luh kar)* — a quarter to eleven
- **C'est mon métier** *(seh mohN may-tyay)* — It's my job
- **comme chien et chat** *(kum shyaN ay shah)* — like cat and dog
- **Je prends** *(zhuh prahN)* — I take

Notice: My, your: mon, mes, votre

Zoé asks « Vous corrigez mes fautes ? » and Gabriel says « votre tambour » and « mon métier ». The possessive agrees with the thing owned: mon tambour, ma porte, mes fautes. With vous, it is votre for one thing and vos for several.

See the table: Grammar tables, Possessive adjectives: my, your, his...

Episode 4 · Le livreur (The delivery rider)

On Tuesday at eleven in the morning, Zoé, in dungarees and green gardening gloves, is repotting by the fig tree in the cobbled courtyard when Yanis rolls in on his electric cargo bike, its red box stacked with parcels. He explains the two Garniers on the sixth floor, then hands her a tiny, heavy parcel for Gabriel and rides off. Zoé shakes it next to her ear, curious.

Zoé Bonjour, monsieur ! C'est vous, les colis du sixième ?
Hello! Are you the one with the sixth-floor parcels? (curious)

Yanis Oui, madame. Quinze colis ce matin. Pas le temps !
Yes, madam. Fifteen parcels this morning. No time! (worried)

Zoé Mes colis arrivent toujours chez le voisin. Pourquoi ?
My parcels always end up at my neighbour's. Why? (annoyed)

Yanis Garnier, sixième étage ? Vous êtes deux Garnier !
Garnier, sixth floor? There are two of you called Garnier! (neutral)

Zoé Oui. Deux Garnier, deux portes. La porte verte, c'est moi.
Yes. Two Garniers, two doors. The green door is me. (neutral)

Yanis Je choisis une porte. Et c'est toujours la mauvaise !
I pick a door. And it's always the wrong one! (amused)

Zoé Et ses colis à lui ? Qu'est-ce qu'il achète ?
And his parcels? What does he buy? (curious)

Yanis Toujours une toute petite boîte. Très lourde.
Always a tiny little box. Very heavy. (neutral)

Zoé Petite et lourde ? Qu'est-ce que c'est ? De l'or ?
Small and heavy? What is it? Gold? (surprised)

Yanis Je ne sais pas. Moi, je ne regarde pas !
I don't know. I don't look! (teasing)

Zoé Des vis ? Des bonbons ? Je donne ma langue au chat.
Screws? Sweets? I give up. (amused)

Yanis Tenez, pour monsieur Garnier. La porte bleue, madame !
Here, for Mr Garnier. The blue door, madam! (teasing)

Words from this episode

- **Bonjour** *(bohN-zhoor)* — Hello
- **Quinze colis** *(kaNz koh-lee)* — fifteen parcels
- **Mes colis arrivent** *(may koh-lee ah-reev)* — My parcels arrive
- **sixième étage** *(see-zyem ay-tahzh)* — sixth floor
- **Je choisis** *(zhuh shwah-zee)* — I choose / I pick
- **la mauvaise** *(lah moh-vez)* — the wrong one
- **Qu'est-ce qu'il achète ?** *(kes-keel ah-shet)* — What does he buy?
- **Qu'est-ce que c'est ?** *(kes-kuh seh)* — What is it?
- **Je ne sais pas** *(zhuh nuh seh pah)* — I don't know
- **je ne regarde pas** *(zhuh nuh ruh-gard pah)* — I don't look

Notice: Asking questions: pourquoi, qu'est-ce que

Zoé asks « Pourquoi ? », « Qu'est-ce qu'il achète ? » and « Qu'est-ce que c'est ? ». Put the question word first, or use qu'est-ce que + subject + verb to ask what. Qu'est-ce que becomes qu'est-ce qu' before il or elle.

See the table: Grammar tables, Question words.

Episode 5 · La panne (The power cut)

On Friday at half past nine at night, the whole building has a power cut. Zoé, her phone dead, feels her way across the dark landing and knocks on the navy door. Gabriel opens with a candle; behind him, shelves of wooden music boxes glow. He winds one, and a tiny tune plays in the dark. They agree on first names, and the lights come back while they are still shaking hands.

Zoé Monsieur Garnier ? Il n'y a pas de lumière !
Mr Garnier? There's no light! (worried)

Gabriel Bonsoir. C'est une panne. Tout l'immeuble.
Good evening. It's a power cut. The whole building. (neutral)

Zoé Je n'ai pas de bougie. Pas de téléphone. Rien !
I've got no candle. No phone. Nothing! (worried)

Gabriel Ne vous inquiétez pas. Moi, j'ai des bougies. Entrez.
Don't worry. I've got candles. Come in. (neutral)

Zoé Oh ! Qu'est-ce que c'est, toutes ces boîtes ?
Oh! What are all these boxes? (surprised)

Gabriel Des boîtes à musique. Je répare les boîtes à musique.
Music boxes. I repair music boxes. (proud)

Zoé Vous ? La musique ? Vous n'aimez pas la musique !
You? Music? You don't like music! (amused)

Gabriel J'aime la petite musique. Écoutez.
I like little music. Listen. (teasing)

Zoé Oh… C'est tout petit. Et très joli.
Oh… It's so tiny. And very pretty. (moved)

Gabriel Pas de tambour. Pas de lumière. Vous entendez ?
No drum. No light. Can you hear it? (curious)

Zoé Bon. On brise la glace ? Appelez-moi Zoé.
Right. Shall we break the ice? Call me Zoé. (amused)

Gabriel D'accord, Zoé. Et moi, c'est Gabriel.
All right, Zoé. And I'm Gabriel. (relieved)

Words from this episode

- **pas de lumière** *(pah duh lew-myair)* — no light
- **Bonsoir** *(bohN-swahr)* — Good evening
- **une panne** *(ewn pahn)* — a power cut
- **des bougies** *(day boo-zhee)* — candles
- **Entrez** *(ahN-tray)* — Come in
- **Vous n'aimez pas** *(voo neh-may pah)* — You don't like
- **Écoutez** *(ay-koo-tay)* — Listen
- **Vous entendez ?** *(voo‿zahN-tahN-day)* — Can you hear?
- **On brise la glace** *(ohN breez lah glahs)* — Let's break the ice
- **D'accord** *(dah-kor)* — All right / OK

Notice: Pas de: no candle, no light

Zoé says « Je n'ai pas de bougie. Pas de téléphone. » and Gabriel answers « j'ai des bougies ». After pas, un, une and des become de: des bougies, pas de bougie. Gabriel uses it too: « Pas de tambour. Pas de lumière. »

See the table: Grammar tables, Pas de: after a negative.

Act 2 · La trêve (The truce)

Level A2

Episode 6 · Le colis ouvert (The opened parcel)

On Monday at seven in the evening, Zoé knocks on the navy door, mortified, holding a small open box spilling two hundred tiny orange earplugs. She was waiting for flower seeds in the same size and paper. Gabriel turns red at his door. She says sorry first, he says sorry for his notes, and they end up laughing, Gabriel with one orange earplug in his ear as a joke.

Zoé Gabriel ? Votre colis est arrivé chez moi. Et je l'ai ouvert.
Gabriel? Your parcel came to my place. And I opened it. (worried)

Gabriel Vous avez ouvert mon colis ?
You opened my parcel? (surprised)

Zoé J'attends des graines. Même taille, même papier… Pardon !
I'm waiting for seeds. Same size, same paper… Sorry! (sad)

Gabriel Et… vous avez vu ce qu'il y a dedans ?
And… did you see what's inside? (worried)

Zoé Oui. Deux cents bouchons d'oreille. Orange.
Yes. Two hundred earplugs. Orange ones. (amused)

Gabriel Je les ai achetés pour vous. Enfin, pour votre tambour.
I bought them for you. Well, for your drum. (sad)

Zoé Oh là là. J'ai mis les pieds dans le plat.
Oh dear. I've really put my foot in it. (amused)

Zoé Deux cents ? Je joue si fort que ça ?
Two hundred? Do I play that loud? (surprised)

Gabriel Non… Mais deux cents, c'est moins cher.
No… But two hundred is cheaper. (amused)

Zoé Je suis désolée, Gabriel. Pour le colis, et pour le bruit.
I'm sorry, Gabriel. For the parcel, and for the noise. (sad)

Gabriel Ça ne fait rien. Et moi aussi, pardon. Pour mes petits mots.
Never mind. And I'm sorry too. For my notes. (moved)

Zoé Ce soir, je vais jouer plus doucement. Promis.
Tonight I'm going to play more softly. Promise. (hopeful)

Words from this episode

- **Votre colis est arrivé** *(voh-truh koh-lee eh ah-ree-vay)* — Your parcel arrived
- **Vous avez ouvert** *(voo‿zah-vay oo-vair)* — You opened
- **J'attends** *(zhah-tahN)* — I'm waiting for
- **Pardon** *(par-dohN)* — Sorry
- **bouchons d'oreille** *(boo-shohN doh-rey)* — earplugs
- **Je les ai achetés** *(zhuh lay‿zay ahsh-tay)* — I bought them
- **J'ai mis les pieds dans le plat** *(zhay mee lay pyay dahN luh plah)* — I put my foot in it
- **Je suis désolée** *(zhuh swee day-zoh-lay)* — I'm sorry
- **je vais jouer** *(zhuh veh zhoo-ay)* — I'm going to play

Notice: Passé composé: être or avoir?

Zoé says « Votre colis est arrivé » (arriver takes être) but « je l'ai ouvert » and « J'ai mis les pieds dans le plat » (avoir). Most verbs take avoir; arriver, venir, monter and a few others take être. With avoir, the participle agrees with a direct object placed before it: « Je les ai achetés » (les = the earplugs).

See the table: Grammar tables, Verbs that take être in the passé composé.

Episode 7 · Le dîner (The dinner)

On Saturday at eight in the evening, Gabriel arrives at Zoé's flat in a dark grey suit and a burgundy tie, holding a tiny cactus in a pot; Zoé is in her dungarees. At the small round table under the fairy lights, her chili is very hot and he drinks the whole water jug. The djembe rolls off its stand, the dinner fails, and they laugh anyway.

Gabriel Bonsoir, Zoé. Je suis un peu en avance. Pardon.
Good evening, Zoé. I'm a little early. Sorry. (worried)

Zoé Pas de souci, Gabriel ! Une cravate ? Pour mon chili ?
No problem, Gabriel! A tie? For my chili? (surprised)

Zoé Vous vous êtes mis sur votre trente et un !
You're dressed to the nines! (teasing)

Gabriel Ma grand-mère a toujours dit : « Pour un dîner, on fait un effort. »
My grandmother always said: "For a dinner, you make an effort." (proud)

Zoé Asseyez-vous. J'ai fait mon chili. Avec un peu de piment.
Sit down. I've made my chili. With a little chilli pepper. (amused)

Gabriel Un peu ? Vous avez mis combien de piments ?
A little? How many chillies did you put in? (worried)

Zoé Seulement six ! À Marseille, ma mère met dix piments.
Only six! In Marseille, my mother puts in ten. (teasing)

Gabriel De l'eau… Encore de l'eau, s'il vous plaît !
Water… More water, please! (worried)

Zoé Vous avez bu toute la carafe ! Bon… le dîner est raté.
You've drunk the whole jug! Well… the dinner's a disaster. (sad)

Gabriel Raté ? Non. J'ai passé une très bonne soirée.
A disaster? No. I've had a very nice evening. (moved)

Gabriel Samedi prochain, je vais faire le dîner. Chez moi.
Next Saturday, I'm going to make dinner. At my place. (hopeful)

Zoé Une soupe, je parie ? Avec une cravate ?
Soup, I bet? With a tie? (teasing)

Words from this episode

- **Bonsoir** *(bohN-swahr)* — Good evening
- **Pardon** *(par-dohN)* — Sorry
- **Asseyez-vous** *(ah-seh-yay voo)* — Sit down
- **J'ai fait mon chili** *(zhay feh mohN shee-lee)* — I've made my chili
- **un peu de piment** *(uhN puh duh pee-mahN)* — a little chilli pepper
- **Vous avez mis** *(voo‿zah-vay mee)* — You put (in)
- **dix piments** *(dee pee-mahN)* — ten chillies
- **Encore de l'eau** *(ahN-kor duh loh)* — More water
- **Vous avez bu** *(voo‿zah-vay bew)* — You drank
- **J'ai passé une très bonne soirée** *(zhay pah-say ewn treh bun swah-ray)* — I've had a very nice evening

Notice: Some water: de l'eau, un peu de

Gabriel begs « De l'eau… Encore de l'eau ! »: du, de la and de l' mean some of something you can't count. After a quantity word, just de: « un peu de piment », « combien de piments ? ».

See the table: Grammar tables, Partitive articles: some.

Episode 8 · Six étages (Six floors)

On Saturday at ten in the morning, the cage lift is broken again and Zoé's thirty-kilo sack of potting soil waits at the bottom of the stairs. Gabriel, coming down with his shopping bag, takes one end. On the fourth-floor half-landing they sit on the steps and Zoé proposes tu. At the top they drop the sack and lie on the chequered tiles under the skylight, laughing.

Zoé L'ascenseur est encore en panne ! Et mes trente kilos de terre !
The lift's broken again! And my thirty kilos of soil! (worried)

Gabriel Bonjour, Zoé. Je vais vous aider. On porte le sac à deux ?
Morning, Zoé. I'll help you. Shall we carry the sack together? (neutral)

Zoé Vous êtes fort, pour un monsieur qui répare de petites boîtes.
You're strong, for a man who repairs little boxes. (teasing)

Gabriel Et vous, vous avez acheté un jardin entier ?
And you, did you buy a whole garden? (teasing)

Zoé On a dîné ensemble deux fois. On a porté la terre ensemble.
We've had dinner together twice. We've carried the soil together. (curious)

Zoé Alors… on se tutoie ?
So… shall we say tu? (hopeful)

Gabriel Se tutoyer ? Je… je n'ai pas l'habitude.
Say tu? I… I'm not used to it. (surprised)

Zoé C'est facile. Répète après moi : « Tu es géniale, Zoé. »
It's easy. Repeat after me: "You're amazing, Zoé." (teasing)

Gabriel Tu es… têtue, Zoé.
You're… stubborn, Zoé. (amused)

Zoé Voilà ! Tu as dit « tu » !
There! You said "tu"! (proud)

Zoé Six étages ! Merci pour le coup de main, Gabriel.
Six floors! Thanks for the help, Gabriel. (relieved)

Gabriel Et ce soir, c'est ton chili. Je vais apporter le dessert.
And tonight it's your chili. I'll bring dessert. (amused)

Words from this episode

- **en panne** *(ahN pahn)* — broken down / out of order
- **trente kilos** *(trahNt kee-loh)* — thirty kilos
- **Bonjour** *(bohN-zhoor)* — Hello / Morning
- **Je vais vous aider** *(zhuh veh voo‿zeh-day)* — I'll help you
- **On porte le sac à deux** *(ohN port luh sahk ah duh)* — We carry the sack together
- **vous avez acheté** *(voo‿zah-vay ahsh-tay)* — you bought
- **on se tutoie** *(ohN suh tew-twah)* — we say tu to each other
- **Tu es** *(tew eh)* — You are (tu)
- **Je vais apporter le dessert** *(zhuh veh ah-por-tay luh deh-sair)* — I'll bring dessert

Notice: From vous to tu

Up to « Vous êtes fort », they say vous. Then Zoé asks « On se tutoie ? » and Gabriel tries « Tu es… têtue ». Friends often switch from vous to tu, and the verb changes too: vous êtes becomes tu es, vous avez becomes tu as.

See the table: Grammar tables, Subject pronouns.

Episode 9 · Le tambour du mercredi (Wednesday drums)

On Wednesday at three in the afternoon, drums and children's laughter come down from the sixth floor. Gabriel crosses the cobbled courtyard with his blue-band mug to Fatou, who is sweeping by the lace-curtained loge. She tells him about Zoé's free lessons, counting on her fingers. Afterwards Gabriel sits alone on the bottom step, turning the small box of orange earplugs over in his hand.

Gabriel Bonjour, madame Diallo. Ce n'est pas pour me plaindre, mais…
Hello, Madame Diallo. I don't mean to complain, but… (neutral)

Fatou Ah ! Le tambour du mercredi ? Tout le monde s'est plaint, au début.
Ah! The Wednesday drum? Everyone complained, at first. (teasing)

Gabriel Le mercredi, c'est toujours plus fort. Pourquoi ?
On Wednesdays it's always louder. Why? (curious)

Fatou Parce que Zoé donne des cours aux enfants de l'immeuble. Gratuits.
Because Zoé gives lessons to the building's children. Free ones. (neutral)

Gabriel Gratuits ? Depuis quand ?
Free? Since when? (surprised)

Fatou Depuis deux ans. Le petit Adam du troisième a retrouvé le sourire.
For two years. Little Adam on the third floor is smiling again. (proud)

Fatou Et l'hiver dernier, elle a porté mes courses. Tous les jours.
And last winter, she carried my shopping. Every day. (teasing)

Fatou Elle a le cœur sur la main, cette petite.
She's got a heart of gold, that girl. (moved)

Gabriel Et moi, je lui ai acheté deux cents bouchons d'oreille.
And I bought her two hundred earplugs. (sad)

Fatou Je sais. Moi, je ne dis rien… mais je vois tout.
I know. I never say a thing… but I see everything. (amused)

Gabriel Le treize, elle va jouer au parc. Je vais aller l'écouter.
On the thirteenth she's playing in the park. I'm going to go and listen. (hopeful)

Fatou Avec une cravate, monsieur Gabriel ?
In a tie, Monsieur Gabriel? (teasing)

Words from this episode

- **Bonjour** *(bohN-zhoor)* — Hello
- **Zoé donne des cours** *(zoh-ay dun day koor)* — Zoé gives lessons
- **Depuis deux ans** *(duh-pwee duh‿zahN)* — For two years
- **a retrouvé le sourire** *(ah ruh-troo-vay luh soo-reer)* — is smiling again
- **l'hiver dernier** *(lee-vair dair-nyay)* — last winter
- **elle a porté mes courses** *(el ah por-tay may koors)* — she carried my shopping
- **le cœur sur la main** *(luh kuhr sewr lah maN)* — a heart of gold (very generous)
- **je lui ai acheté** *(zhuh lwee ay ahsh-tay)* — I bought her
- **Je vais aller l'écouter** *(zhuh veh ah-lay lay-koo-tay)* — I'm going to go and listen to her

Notice: When: le mercredi, depuis, l'hiver dernier

Fatou says « le mercredi » (every Wednesday), « au début », « depuis deux ans » and « l'hiver dernier ». Depuis + a length of time means for, with the action still going on. A date takes le + number: « Le treize, elle va jouer au parc ».

See the table: Grammar tables, Common time expressions.

Episode 10 · Le trac (Stage fright)

On Sunday at four in the afternoon, behind the small wooden stage of the winter festival in the Parc de Belleville, Zoé, in a gold sequinned jacket over her dungarees, holds her drumsticks, pale. Gabriel arrives in his navy coat and grey scarf with a small pale-wood music box. He sits in the front row while she plays, and after the concert she kisses him on the cheek; he goes red, his scarf crooked.

Zoé Gabriel ! Tu es venu ! J'ai le trac. Je vais tout rater.
Gabriel! You came! I've got stage fright. I'm going to mess it all up. (worried)

Gabriel Toi ? Le trac ? Tu n'as peur de rien !
You? Stage fright? You're not afraid of anything! (surprised)

Zoé Devant deux cents personnes, si. J'ai toujours eu le trac.
In front of two hundred people, I am. I've always had stage fright. (sad)

Gabriel Toujours ? Et tu as joué combien de fois ?
Always? And how many times have you played? (curious)

Zoé Cent fois. Et cent fois, mes mains ont tremblé.
A hundred times. And a hundred times, my hands have shaken. (amused)

Gabriel Tiens. Je l'ai réparée pour toi. Écoute.
Here. I've repaired it for you. Listen. (hopeful)

Zoé C'est doux… Mon cœur va moins vite.
It's gentle… My heart's slowing down. (moved)

Gabriel Tu vas jouer. Et moi, je vais être au premier rang.
You're going to play. And I'm going to be in the front row. (hopeful)

Zoé Au premier rang ? Sans bouchons d'oreille ?
In the front row? Without earplugs? (teasing)

Gabriel Je les ai jetés mercredi.
I threw them away on Wednesday. (amused)

Zoé Tu as vu ? Je n'ai rien raté ! C'est génial !
Did you see? I didn't mess anything up! It's amazing! (proud)

Gabriel Tu as été formidable. Et… c'est pour le premier rang, ce bisou ?
You were wonderful. And… is that kiss for the front row? (surprised)

Words from this episode

- **Tu es venu** *(tew eh vuh-new)* — You came
- **Je vais tout rater** *(zhuh veh too rah-tay)* — I'm going to mess it all up
- **tu as joué** *(tew ah zhoo-ay)* — you played
- **Je l'ai réparée** *(zhuh lay ray-pah-ray)* — I repaired it
- **Écoute** *(ay-koot)* — Listen
- **au premier rang** *(oh pruh-myay rahN)* — in the front row
- **Je les ai jetés** *(zhuh lay‿zay zhuh-tay)* — I threw them away
- **Tu as vu ?** *(tew ah vew)* — Did you see?
- **C'est génial !** *(seh zhay-nyahl)* — It's amazing!

Notice: Near future: aller + infinitive

Zoé panics: « Je vais tout rater. » Gabriel answers: « Tu vas jouer. Et moi, je vais être au premier rang. » To say what is going to happen, use aller in the present + an infinitive.

See the table: Grammar tables, Futur simple: endings and irregular stems.

Act 3 · Avant (Before (A2+))

Level A2

Episode 11 · La boîte cassée (The broken music box)

On a snowy Friday evening in January, Zoé, waiting for the tea in Gabriel's workshop, reaches for a small walnut music box alone on a high shelf. Gabriel stops her and tells her its story under the green lamp. While he pours the tea, Zoé looks closely at the broken tooth of the comb. When he winds the box, she sings the missing note.

Gabriel Attention, Zoé ! Ne touche pas. Cette boîte est très fragile.
Careful, Zoé! Don't touch. That box is very fragile. (worried)

Zoé Pourquoi elle est toute seule, là-haut ? Elle est cassée ?
Why is it all alone up there? Is it broken? (curious)

Gabriel Oui. C'était la boîte de ma grand-mère, Mamie Jeanne.
Yes. It was my grandmother's box, Mamie Jeanne's. (sad)

Gabriel L'été, j'habitais chez elle, dans le Jura. Elle réparait des boîtes à musique.
In summer I lived at her place, in the Jura. She repaired music boxes. (neutral)

Zoé Et cette boîte, qu'est-ce qu'elle jouait ?
And that box, what did it play? (curious)

Gabriel « À la claire fontaine ». Le soir, Mamie chantait avec elle.
"À la claire fontaine". In the evening, Mamie sang along with it. (moved)

Zoé Mais c'est ton métier ! Pourquoi tu ne la répares pas ?
But it's your job! Why don't you repair it? (surprised)

Gabriel À dix ans, je l'ai trop remontée. Une dent du peigne s'est cassée.
When I was ten, I wound it too tight. A tooth of the comb broke. (sad)

Gabriel Depuis, il manque une note. J'ai peur de la casser encore.
Since then, one note has been missing. I'm afraid of breaking it again. (worried)

Zoé Elle ne tourne pas rond, ta boîte. Un peu comme toi.
Your box isn't running right. A bit like you. (teasing)

Gabriel Merci beaucoup.
Thanks a lot. (amused)

Zoé Écoute. Je chante la note qui manque… Là !
Listen. I'll sing the missing note… There! (hopeful)

Gabriel Tu as trouvé la note. Bon… je devrais peut-être la réparer.
You found the note. Well… maybe I should repair it. (moved)

Words from this episode

- **Ne touche pas** *(nuh toosh pah)* — Don't touch
- **j'habitais chez elle** *(zhah-bee-teh shay‿zel)* — I lived at her place
- **Elle réparait** *(el ray-pah-reh)* — She used to repair
- **Mamie chantait** *(mah-mee shahN-teh)* — Mamie used to sing
- **Elle ne tourne pas rond** *(el nuh toorn pah rohN)* — It isn't running right
- **Merci beaucoup** *(mair-see boh-koo)* — Thanks a lot
- **la note qui manque** *(lah nut kee mahNk)* — the missing note
- **Tu as trouvé** *(tew ah troo-vay)* — You found
- **je devrais** *(zhuh duh-vreh)* — I should
- **je devrais peut-être la réparer** *(zhuh duh-vreh puh-teh-truh lah ray-pah-ray)* — maybe I should repair it

Notice: The imparfait: what used to happen

Gabriel remembers: « j'habitais chez elle », « Elle réparait des boîtes à musique », « Mamie chantait avec elle ». The imparfait describes habits and background in the past. One event takes the passé composé: « je l'ai trop remontée », « Une dent du peigne s'est cassée ».

See the table: Grammar tables, Imparfait: how things were, what used to happen.

Episode 12 · Comme des sardines (Like sardines)

On a sunny Sunday afternoon in January, on an old blue tarp in Zoé's flat full of plants, she teaches Gabriel to repot tomato seedlings; his sleeves are rolled up and he holds a seedling at arm's length, soil up to his wrists. They talk about their childhoods, Zoé shows him her saucepan drums, and then they sit side by side on the mustard-yellow sofa for five quiet minutes, eyes closed.

Zoé Non, pas comme ça ! Doucement. Une plante, ce n'est pas une montre.
No, not like that! Gently. A plant isn't a watch. (teasing)

Gabriel Une montre, au moins, ça ne met pas de terre partout.
A watch, at least, doesn't put soil everywhere. (annoyed)

Gabriel Tu avais des plantes, quand tu étais petite ?
Did you have plants when you were little? (curious)

Zoé Des plantes ? Non ! À Marseille, on était neuf dans trois pièces.
Plants? No! In Marseille there were nine of us in three rooms. (amused)

Zoé Six enfants, mes parents, ma grand-mère… On était serrés comme des sardines !
Six children, my parents, my grandmother… We were packed like sardines! (amused)

Gabriel Neuf ? Et c'était bruyant ?
Nine? And was it noisy? (surprised)

Zoé Tout le temps. Personne ne m'écoutait. Alors je tapais sur les casseroles.
All the time. Nobody listened to me. So I banged on the saucepans. (neutral)

Zoé Maintenant, la nuit, le silence… ça me fait un peu peur.
Now, at night, the silence… it scares me a little. (sad)

Gabriel Chez nous, à Besançon, c'était le contraire. On chuchotait.
At our house in Besançon, it was the opposite. We whispered. (moved)

Gabriel Ma sœur et moi, on lisait. Toute la maison faisait « chut ».
My sister and I read. The whole house went "shh". (amused)

Gabriel Tu devrais essayer le silence. Cinq minutes. Avec moi.
You should try silence. Five minutes. With me. (hopeful)

Zoé Cinq minutes… Avec toi, le silence, c'est doux. Ça me plaît.
Five minutes… With you, silence is soft. I like it. (surprised)

Zoé Et toi, tu devrais essayer le bruit. Samedi, je t'apprends le tambour !
And you should try noise. On Saturday, I'm teaching you the drum! (teasing)

Words from this episode

- **on était neuf dans trois pièces** *(ohN‿nay-teh nuhf dahN trwah pyes)* — there were nine of us in three rooms
- **Personne ne m'écoutait** *(pair-sun nuh may-koo-teh)* — Nobody listened to me
- **je tapais** *(zhuh tah-peh)* — I used to bang
- **On chuchotait** *(ohN shew-shoh-teh)* — We whispered
- **on lisait** *(ohN lee-zeh)* — we used to read
- **Tu devrais essayer** *(tew duh-vreh eh-seh-yay)* — You should try
- **essayer le silence** *(eh-seh-yay luh see-lahNs)* — try silence
- **Ça me plaît** *(sah muh pleh)* — I like it
- **tu devrais** *(tew duh-vreh)* — you should
- **je t'apprends** *(zhuh tah-prahN)* — I'll teach you

Notice: Friendly advice: tu devrais

Gabriel says « Tu devrais essayer le silence » and Zoé answers « Et toi, tu devrais essayer le bruit ». Devoir in the conditional + an infinitive gives soft, friendly advice: je devrais, tu devrais, vous devriez. It is gentler than tu dois (you must).

See the table: Grammar tables, Conditional: would, could, polite requests.

Episode 13 · La valise verte (The green suitcase)

On a grey Tuesday morning in February, Yanis rides into the courtyard on his cargo bike with parcels. Zoé, in her mustard cardigan, arms crossed, tells him what she saw through her peephole the night before: Gabriel hugging a tall woman with a brown bob and a green wheeled suitcase. Yanis, a cinema student, frames her with his fingers like a film director, and she half laughs despite herself.

Yanis Garnier ? Bonjour, madame ! Un colis pour… vous, cette fois !
Garnier? Morning, madam! A parcel for… you, this time! (amused)

Zoé Merci, Yanis. Et pour le voisin, vous avez quelque chose ?
Thanks, Yanis. And have you got anything for the neighbour? (neutral)

Yanis Oui. Petit et lourd, comme toujours. Vous le prenez ?
Yes. Small and heavy, as always. Will you take it? (teasing)

Zoé Non. Il a de la visite. Une femme.
No. He's got a visitor. A woman. (annoyed)

Yanis Une femme ? Elle était comment ?
A woman? What was she like? (curious)

Zoé Grande, très belle. Elle avait une valise verte. Elle riait fort.
Tall, very beautiful. She had a green suitcase. She laughed loudly. (neutral)

Zoé Il la serrait dans ses bras. Ils avaient l'air très contents.
He was hugging her. They looked very happy. (sad)

Zoé Elle va rester. Ils vont se marier. Et moi, je vais déménager !
She's going to stay. They're going to get married. And I'm going to move out! (worried)

Yanis Madame Zoé, vous vous faites un film !
Madame Zoé, you're imagining a whole film! (amused)

Zoé Un film ? Je l'ai vue, Yanis !
A film? I saw her, Yanis! (annoyed)

Yanis Vous avez vu une valise. Le reste, c'est votre film.
You saw a suitcase. The rest is your film. (teasing)

Yanis Vous devriez lui demander. C'est plus simple.
You should ask him. It's simpler. (neutral)

Zoé Vous avez raison. Je vais lui demander… demain.
You're right. I'm going to ask him… tomorrow. (hopeful)

Words from this episode

- **Bonjour** *(bohN-zhoor)* — Hello / Morning
- **Petit et lourd** *(puh-tee ay loor)* — small and heavy
- **Vous le prenez ?** *(voo luh pruh-nay)* — Will you take it?
- **Elle avait une valise verte** *(el ah-veh ewn vah-leez vairt)* — She had a green suitcase
- **Elle riait fort** *(el ree-yeh for)* — She laughed loudly
- **Ils avaient l'air très contents** *(eel‿zah-veh lehr treh kohN-tahN)* — They looked very happy
- **Elle va rester** *(el vah res-tay)* — She's going to stay
- **Vous devriez** *(voo duh-vree-yay)* — You should
- **lui demander** *(lwee duh-mahN-day)* — ask him

Notice: Adjectives agree: grande, verte, contents

Zoé describes the woman: « Grande, très belle » and « une valise verte ». Adjectives take -e for a feminine noun and -s for a plural one: « Ils avaient l'air très contents ». For the parcel (masculine), Yanis says « Petit et lourd ».

See the table: Grammar tables, Regular agreement patterns.

Episode 14 · La sœur (The sister)

On Wednesday at seven in the evening, in Gabriel's workshop, his sister Hélène, her bottle-green coat thrown over the armchair and her red scarf still around her neck, opens a round blue tin on the workbench: it is full of Zoé's yellow notes, stacked in order. Gabriel tries to grab it. Later she laughs, hands on hips, while he sits on his stool with his head in his hands, ears red.

Hélène Gabriel, c'est quoi, cette boîte en fer ? Des petits papiers jaunes ?
Gabriel, what's this tin? Little yellow papers? (curious)

Gabriel Ne touche pas ! Ce n'est rien. De vieux papiers.
Don't touch! It's nothing. Old papers. (worried)

Hélène « Ce soir, pas de stylo rouge. Zoé. » Tu les as tous gardés ?
"*Tonight, no red pen. Zoé.*" *You've kept them all?* (teasing)

Gabriel Oui. Tous. Dans l'ordre.
Yes. All of them. In order. (sad)

Hélène Quand tu étais petit, tu étais déjà fleur bleue.
When you were little, you were already a big romantic. (amused)

Gabriel Hier, Zoé m'a dit bonjour très froidement. Pourquoi, à ton avis ?
Yesterday Zoé said hello to me very coldly. Why, do you think? (curious)

Hélène Lundi soir, sur le palier… Elle nous a vus ! Toi et moi !
Monday night, on the landing… She saw us! You and me! (surprised)

Hélène Elle croit que je suis ta fiancée, petit frère !
She thinks I'm your fiancée, little brother! (amused)

Gabriel Ma fiancée ? Mais tu es ma sœur !
My fiancée? But you're my sister! (surprised)

Hélène Elle ne le savait pas, gros malin.
She didn't know that, you big genius. (amused)

Hélène Tu devrais aller lui expliquer. Et lui dire le reste.
You should go and explain. And tell her the rest. (hopeful)

Gabriel Le reste ? Hélène, on est trop différents, elle et moi.
The rest? Hélène, we're too different, she and I. (worried)

Hélène Mamie Jeanne disait : les boîtes qui vont bien ensemble ne sont jamais pareilles.
Mamie Jeanne used to say: boxes that go well together are never the same. (moved)

Words from this episode

- **Tu les as tous gardés ?** *(tew lay‿zah toos gar-day)* — You've kept them all?
- **Quand tu étais petit** *(kahN tew ay-teh puh-tee)* — When you were little
- **fleur bleue** *(fluhr bluh)* — romantic, sentimental
- **dit bonjour** *(dee bohN-zhoor)* — said hello
- **Elle nous a vus** *(el noo‿zah vew)* — She saw us
- **Elle croit que** *(el krwah kuh)* — She thinks that
- **Elle ne le savait pas** *(el nuh luh sah-veh pah)* — She didn't know it
- **Tu devrais** *(tew duh-vreh)* — You should
- **lui expliquer** *(lwee eks-plee-kay)* — explain to her
- **elle et moi** *(el ay mwah)* — she and I

Notice: Le, la, les, nous before the verb

Hélène asks « Tu les as tous gardés ? » (les = the notes) and says « Elle nous a vus » and « Elle ne le savait pas ». Direct object pronouns go before the verb, and in the passé composé the participle agrees with them: gardés, vus. Compare lui (to her): « lui expliquer, lui dire le reste ».

See the table: Grammar tables, Direct object pronouns: me, le, la...

Episode 15 · Les pendules à l'heure (Setting things straight)

On Thursday at half past seven in the evening, Yanis has left Zoé's big lumpy parcel at the navy door, of course. Gabriel knocks on the half-open green door with it; Zoé, arms crossed, is cold. He tells her the woman was his sister, and she laughs into her hands. Then they stand very close under the skylight, until a door bangs downstairs and they step back, smiling.

Gabriel Bonsoir, Zoé. Je crois que c'est à toi.
Good evening, Zoé. I think this is yours. (neutral)

Zoé Encore toi ! Merci. Tu peux le poser là.
You again! Thanks. You can put it down there. (annoyed)

Gabriel Depuis lundi, tu es bizarre. Tu ne joues plus. Tu ne ris plus.
Since Monday you've been strange. You don't play any more. You don't laugh any more. (curious)

Zoé Lundi soir, je t'ai vu sur le palier. Avec une femme.
On Monday night I saw you on the landing. With a woman. (sad)

Zoé Je pensais que tu avais une amoureuse. Voilà.
I thought you had a girlfriend. There. (sad)

Gabriel Bon. On remet les pendules à l'heure ?
Right. Shall we set things straight? (amused)

Gabriel C'était Hélène, ma sœur. Elle conduit des TGV. Elle passe la semaine chez moi.
That was Hélène, my sister. She drives TGV trains. She's staying with me this week. (amused)

Zoé Ta sœur ? Mais elle riait si fort… comme moi !
Your sister? But she laughed so loudly… like me! (surprised)

Zoé Oh là là. Je me faisais un film.
Oh dear. I was imagining a whole film. (relieved)

Gabriel Un long film. Avec une fin très triste.
A long film. With a very sad ending. (teasing)

Zoé La prochaine fois, tu devrais me présenter ta famille !
Next time, you should introduce me to your family! (teasing)

Gabriel Et toi, la prochaine fois, tu devrais me demander.
And you, next time, should just ask me. (hopeful)

Zoé Demain soir, je fais un chili. Ça te dit ? Hélène aussi est invitée.
Tomorrow night I'm making chili. Do you fancy it? Hélène's invited too. (hopeful)

Words from this episode

- **Bonsoir** *(bohN-swahr)* — Good evening
- **Tu peux le poser là** *(tew puh luh poh-zay lah)* — You can put it down there
- **Tu ne ris plus** *(tew nuh ree plew)* — You don't laugh any more
- **Je pensais que** *(zhuh pahN-seh kuh)* — I thought that
- **tu avais** *(tew ah-veh)* — you had
- **On remet les pendules à l'heure** *(ohN ruh-meh lay pahN-dewl ah luhr)* — Let's set things straight
- **Elle conduit des TGV** *(el kohN-dwee day tay-zhay-vay)* — She drives TGV trains
- **tu devrais** *(tew duh-vreh)* — you should
- **tu devrais me demander** *(tew duh-vreh muh duh-mahN-day)* — you should ask me
- **est invitée** *(eh aN-vee-tay)* — is invited

Notice: Imparfait or passé composé?

Zoé tells one event in the passé composé: « je t'ai vu sur le palier ». What she believed and what was going on is in the imparfait: « Je pensais que tu avais une amoureuse », « elle riait si fort », « Je me faisais un film ».

See the table: Grammar tables, Imparfait: how things were, what used to happen.

Act 4 · Ce qu'on voudrait (What we'd like)

Level B1

Episode 16 · La lettre (The letter)

On Monday evening in March, two identical thick white envelopes lie on the two doormats: on Thursday the building votes on banning musical instruments in the flats. Zoé holds hers, pale; Gabriel opens his door with the other. They sit on the top stair, the envelope on her knees, and their hands almost touch as he says the landing would be too quiet without her.

Zoé Gabriel, tu as lu la lettre ? Jeudi, l'immeuble va voter.
Gabriel, have you read the letter? On Thursday the building is going to vote. (worried)

Gabriel Oui. Plus d'instruments de musique dans les appartements.
Yes. No more musical instruments in the flats. (neutral)

Zoé C'est monsieur Perrot, le nouveau du cinquième. Il ne m'a jamais dit bonjour.
It's Monsieur Perrot, the new man on the fifth floor. He's never even said hello to me. (annoyed)

Gabriel Au début, moi aussi, je voulais du silence. Tu te souviens ?
At the start, I wanted silence too. Remember? (teasing)

Zoé Oui, mais toi, au moins, tu as frappé à ma porte.
Yes, but at least you knocked on my door. (sad)

Zoé Sans musique, je ne pourrais plus donner mes cours du mercredi.
Without music, I couldn't give my Wednesday lessons any more. (sad)

Zoé Je pourrais partir. Il y a un studio à Montreuil, avec un garage.
I could leave. There's a studio in Montreuil, with a garage. (worried)

Gabriel Partir ? Tu aimerais partir d'ici ?
Leave? Would you like to leave this place? (surprised)

Zoé Non. J'aimerais rester. Mais je voudrais aussi jouer.
No. I'd like to stay. But I'd like to play too. (hopeful)

Gabriel Ce serait dommage… pour l'immeuble. J'ai le cœur gros, rien que d'y penser.
It would be a shame… for the building. My heart sinks just thinking about it. (sad)

Zoé Toi ? Le monsieur aux deux cents bouchons d'oreille ?
You? The man with the two hundred earplugs? (surprised)

Gabriel Ce palier, sans toi, ce serait trop calme. Beaucoup trop calme.
This landing, without you, would be too quiet. Far too quiet. (moved)

Zoé Tu pourrais venir jeudi ? À la réunion ?
Could you come on Thursday? To the meeting? (moved)

Gabriel Je vais venir. Et je vais trouver une idée.
I'll come. And I'll think of something. (proud)

Words from this episode

- **dit bonjour** *(dee bohN-zhoor)* — said hello
- **je voulais** *(zhuh voo-leh)* — I wanted
- **Tu te souviens ?** *(tew tuh soo-vyaN)* — Do you remember?
- **je ne pourrais plus** *(zhuh nuh poo-reh plew)* — I couldn't any more
- **Je pourrais partir** *(zhuh poo-reh par-teer)* — I could leave
- **Tu aimerais** *(tew em-reh)* — Would you like
- **J'aimerais rester** *(zhem-reh res-tay)* — I'd like to stay
- **d'y penser** *(dee pahN-say)* — thinking about it
- **J'ai le cœur gros** *(zhay luh kuhr groh)* — My heart is heavy
- **Tu pourrais venir** *(tew poo-reh vuh-neer)* — Could you come

Notice: Wishes and polite forms: the conditional

Zoé says « Je pourrais partir » and « J'aimerais rester. Mais je voudrais aussi jouer. » Gabriel answers « Ce palier, sans toi, ce serait trop calme. » The conditional (endings -ais, -ait) softens a wish, an offer or a possibility: « Tu pourrais venir jeudi ? »

See the table: Grammar tables, Conditional: would, could, polite requests.

Episode 17 · La cave (The cellar)

On Wednesday at four in the afternoon, faint drums and children's laughter drift down from Zoé's sixth-floor class. Gabriel has been pacing the courtyard; Fatou, in her headwrap, waves him over to the loge with a big ring of old iron keys. She tells him her story, then leads him down to the vaulted stone cellar under the courtyard, lit by one bulb, where he presses his palms to the thick walls. At her last question he blushes and says nothing.

Fatou Monsieur Gabriel, vous avez la tête des mauvais jours.
Monsieur Gabriel, you look like you're having a bad day. (teasing)

Gabriel Madame Diallo, je voudrais aider Zoé. Mais je ne sais pas comment.
Madame Diallo, I'd like to help Zoé. But I don't know how. (worried)

Fatou Alors, je vais vous raconter un secret. Asseyez-vous.
Then I'm going to tell you a secret. Sit down. (amused)

Fatou En quatre-vingt-onze, le facteur mettait les lettres de Moussa dans ma boîte.
In ninety-one, the postman used to put Moussa's letters in my letterbox. (moved)

Fatou Chaque semaine, je les montais au troisième. Un jour, Moussa m'a invitée.
Every week, I took them up to the third floor. One day, Moussa asked me out. (amused)

Gabriel Un facteur qui se trompe ? Et vous êtes mariés depuis… ?
A postman who gets it wrong? And you've been married for…? (surprised)

Fatou Trente-cinq ans ! Les erreurs de facteur, ça marche.
Thirty-five years! Postmen's mistakes work out. (proud)

Fatou Vous devriez lui dire ce que vous ressentez. Avant jeudi.
You should tell her what you feel. Before Thursday. (neutral)

Gabriel Je voudrais. Mais d'abord, j'aimerais sauver sa musique.
I'd like to. But first, I'd like to save her music. (sad)

Fatou Il y a la vieille cave, sous la cour, où personne ne va.
There's the old cellar, under the courtyard, where nobody goes. (curious)

Gabriel Les murs sont épais… On pourrait en faire une salle de musique !
The walls are thick… We could turn it into a music room! (hopeful)

Gabriel Je pourrais isoler la porte et le plafond. Je sais faire.
I could soundproof the door and the ceiling. I know how. (proud)

Gabriel Demain, je vais prendre mon courage à deux mains.
Tomorrow, I'm going to pluck up my courage. (hopeful)

Fatou Et après la réunion, vous allez lui dire le reste ?
And after the meeting, are you going to tell her the rest? (teasing)

Words from this episode

- **je voudrais aider Zoé** *(zhuh voo-dreh eh-day zoh-ay)* — I'd like to help Zoé
- **je ne sais pas** *(zhuh nuh seh pah)* — I don't know
- **je vais vous raconter** *(zhuh veh voo rah-kohN-tay)* — I'm going to tell you
- **le facteur mettait** *(luh fahk-tuhr meh-teh)* — the postman used to put
- **Moussa m'a invitée** *(moo-sah mah aN-vee-tay)* — Moussa asked me out
- **Un facteur qui se trompe** *(uhN fahk-tuhr kee suh trohNp)* — A postman who gets it wrong
- **ça marche** *(sah marsh)* — it works
- **Vous devriez** *(voo duh-vree-yay)* — You should
- **où personne ne va** *(oo pair-sun nuh vah)* — where nobody goes
- **On pourrait** *(ohN poo-reh)* — We could

Notice: Qui, que, où: linking ideas

Gabriel asks « Un facteur qui se trompe ? » (qui is the subject of the verb). Fatou says « lui dire ce que vous ressentez » (que is the object) and « la vieille cave, où personne ne va » (où is a place).

See the table: Grammar tables, Relative pronouns: qui, que, où, dont.

Episode 18 · La réunion (The meeting)

On Thursday at half past nine at night, after the building meeting in the ground-floor hall, Zoé and Gabriel climb the old staircase. He stood up in front of everyone in his suit and burgundy tie, and the cellar music room won the vote. Zoé, two steps above him, turns back, amazed; his tie is loosened. Just as he starts to tell her something, the stair light's timer clicks off, and they laugh in the dark.

Zoé Gabriel ! Tu t'es levé devant tout l'immeuble. Toi, le timide !
Gabriel! You stood up in front of the whole building. You, the shy one! (surprised)

Gabriel J'ai pris mon courage à deux mains. Et mes genoux tremblaient.
I plucked up my courage. And my knees were shaking. (proud)

Zoé Qu'est-ce que tu leur as dit, exactement ? J'avais trop le trac pour écouter.
What exactly did you tell them? I was too nervous to listen. (curious)

Gabriel Je leur ai dit que ta musique faisait vivre l'immeuble.
I told them your music brought the building to life. (neutral)

Gabriel Et que les enfants du mercredi méritaient une vraie salle. La cave.
And that the Wednesday children deserved a real room. The cellar. (neutral)

Zoé Ils ont voté oui. Même monsieur Perrot ! Je n'en reviens pas !
They voted yes. Even Monsieur Perrot! I can't believe it! (moved)

Gabriel Monsieur Perrot a un petit-fils qui voudrait apprendre la batterie.
Monsieur Perrot has a grandson who'd like to learn the drums. (amused)

Zoé Toi, le roi du silence, tu as défendu mon tambour. C'est génial !
You, the king of silence, stood up for my drum. It's amazing! (amused)

Gabriel J'aimerais construire la salle avec toi. On pourrait commencer samedi ?
I'd like to build the room with you. Could we start on Saturday? (hopeful)

Zoé Tu sais quoi ? On est sur la même longueur d'onde.
You know what? We're on the same wavelength. (moved)

Gabriel Toi, le tambour, et moi, la petite boîte ? La même longueur d'onde ?
You, the drum, and me, the little box? The same wavelength? (curious)

Zoé Le tambour garde le rythme. La petite boîte garde la mélodie. Ensemble, ce serait une chanson.
The drum keeps the rhythm. The little box keeps the tune. Together, it would be a song. (teasing)

Gabriel Zoé… je voudrais te dire quelque chose. Depuis longtemps.
Zoé… I'd like to tell you something. I've wanted to for a long time. (hopeful)

Zoé Le noir, encore ! Tu vas me le dire demain, alors.
The dark, again! You'll have to tell me tomorrow, then. (amused)

Words from this episode

- **Tu t'es levé** *(tew teh luh-vay)* — You stood up
- **tu leur as dit** *(tew luhr ah dee)* — you told them
- **Je leur ai dit** *(zhuh luhr ay dee)* — I told them
- **Ils ont voté oui** *(eel‿zohN voh-tay wee)* — They voted yes
- **apprendre la batterie** *(ah-prahN-druh lah bah-tree)* — learn the drums
- **C'est génial** *(seh zhay-nyahl)* — It's amazing
- **J'aimerais construire** *(zhem-reh kohN-strweer)* — I'd like to build
- **On pourrait commencer** *(ohN poo-reh koh-mahN-say)* — We could start
- **sur la même longueur d'onde** *(sewr lah mem lohN-guhr dohNd)* — on the same wavelength
- **je voudrais te dire** *(zhuh voo-dreh tuh deer)* — I'd like to tell you

Notice: Leur, te, me: to them, to you, to me

Zoé asks « Qu'est-ce que tu leur as dit ? » and Gabriel answers « Je leur ai dit que… » (leur = to them). Then « je voudrais te dire quelque chose » (te = to you) and « Tu vas me le dire demain » (me = to me). These pronouns go before the verb, or before the infinitive.

See the table: Grammar tables, Indirect object pronouns: me, lui, leur...

Episode 19 · La note qui manque (The missing note)

On Saturday at eleven in the morning, in the workshop, a small wooden box tied with red string from the Jura lies open on the workbench; a gleaming steel comb shines in Gabriel's palm and Zoé beams beside him. With his loupe and tiny screwdriver he fits it while she holds the green lamp closer. The walnut box plays the whole song at last, Gabriel says what he feels, and they share a gentle first kiss, foreheads together above the box.

Zoé Gabriel ! Un colis du Jura ! Il est arrivé chez moi, ce matin.
Gabriel! A parcel from the Jura! It came to my place this morning. (proud)

Gabriel À ta porte ? Alors il est pour toi.
At your door? Then it's for you. (curious)

Zoé Non, il est pour toi. Mais c'est moi qui l'ai commandé.
No, it's for you. But I'm the one who ordered it. (teasing)

Gabriel Un peigne… pour la boîte de Mamie Jeanne ? Où est-ce que tu l'as trouvé ?
A comb… for Mamie Jeanne's box? Where did you find it? (surprised)

Zoé J'ai appelé Hélène. Hélène a appelé Mamie Jeanne. Elle l'avait dans son vieux tiroir.
I called Hélène. Hélène called Mamie Jeanne. She had it in her old drawer. (proud)

Zoé Elle a dit : « Mon petit ne devrait plus avoir peur. »
She said: "My boy shouldn't be afraid any more." (hopeful)

Gabriel Et si je la casse encore ?
What if I break it again? (worried)

Zoé Alors on va en trouver un autre. Vas-y, je tiens la lampe.
Then we'll find another one. Go on, I'll hold the lamp. (teasing)

Zoé Elle est complète… Tu connais les paroles ?
It's complete… Do you know the words? (moved)

Gabriel « Il y a longtemps que je t'aime, jamais je ne t'oublierai. »
"I've loved you for a long time, I'll never forget you." (moved)

Gabriel Ce n'est pas seulement la chanson, Zoé. C'est moi qui te le dis.
It's not just the song, Zoé. It's me saying it to you. (hopeful)

Zoé Tu en pinces pour moi depuis quand, monsieur Garnier ?
Since when have you had a crush on me, Mr Garnier? (amused)

Gabriel Depuis le tambour. Ou depuis tes fautes d'orthographe.
Since the drum. Or since your spelling mistakes. (amused)

Zoé Moi aussi. Depuis la bougie.
Me too. Since the candle. (moved)

Words from this episode

- **Où est-ce que tu l'as trouvé ?** *(oo es-kuh tew lah troo-vay)* — Where did you find it?
- **J'ai appelé Hélène** *(zhay ah-play ay-len)* — I called Hélène
- **ne devrait plus avoir peur** *(nuh duh-vreh plew ah-vwahr puhr)* — shouldn't be afraid any more
- **on va en trouver un autre** *(ohN vah ahN troo-vay uhN‿noh-truh)* — we'll find another one
- **je tiens la lampe** *(zhuh tyaN lah lahNp)* — I'll hold the lamp
- **Tu connais les paroles ?** *(tew koh-neh lay pah-rul)* — Do you know the words?
- **je t'aime** *(zhuh tem)* — I love you
- **jamais je ne t'oublierai** *(zhah-meh zhuh nuh too-blee-reh)* — I'll never forget you
- **Tu en pinces pour moi** *(tew ahN paNs poor mwah)* — You've got a crush on me
- **Moi aussi** *(mwah oh-see)* — Me too

Notice: En: of them, and in idioms

Zoé says « on va en trouver un autre »: en stands for « of them » (another comb). In « Tu en pinces pour moi ? », en is simply part of the idiom. Compare y in episode 16: « rien que d'y penser » (y = about it).

See the table: Grammar tables, Y and en.

Episode 20 · Le bon colis (The right parcel)

On Saturday at ten in the morning, spring sun falls through the skylight onto the landing. Both doors stand wide open, and exactly in the middle of the chequered tiles waits a square wooden box tied with red string, left there by Yanis. Gabriel and Zoé crouch on either side of it and open it together: Mamie Jeanne's very first music box, with two mother-of-pearl birds. Later the landing becomes a tiny living room between the open doors.

Gabriel Bonjour. Je crois que c'est à nous.
Morning. I think this is ours. (amused)

Zoé À nous ? Yanis l'a posé au milieu ? Entre les deux portes ?
Ours? Yanis put it in the middle? Between the two doors? (surprised)

Gabriel Pour une fois, il n'a pas choisi la mauvaise porte.
For once, he didn't pick the wrong door. (amused)

Zoé Il y a écrit : « Pour les deux Garnier. » C'est Mamie Jeanne !
It says: "For the two Garniers." It's from Mamie Jeanne! (curious)

Zoé Une boîte à musique… avec deux oiseaux. Un pour toi, un pour moi.
A music box… with two birds. One for you, one for me. (moved)

Gabriel C'est sa toute première boîte. Elle nous la donne.
It's her very first box. She's giving it to us. (moved)

Zoé Et elle joue quoi ?
And what does it play? (curious)

Gabriel Je ne sais pas. On pourrait l'écouter… tous les deux.
I don't know. We could listen to it… together. (hopeful)

Zoé Tu te souviens ? Le premier soir, on était comme le jour et la nuit.
Remember? The first evening, we were like night and day. (amused)

Gabriel Maintenant, on est comme le matin et le soir. Ensemble, on fait une journée.
Now we're like morning and evening. Together, we make a day. (teasing)

Zoé On pourrait laisser les deux portes ouvertes. Le palier, ce serait notre salon.
We could leave both doors open. The landing would be our living room. (hopeful)

Gabriel Et Yanis ne se tromperait plus jamais.
And Yanis would never get it wrong again. (amused)

Zoé Tu sais, j'ai trouvé chaussure à mon pied. Une chaussure très bien rangée.
You know, I've found my perfect match. A very tidy one. (amused)

Gabriel La mauvaise porte, c'était la bonne.
The wrong door was the right one. (moved)

Words from this episode

- **Bonjour** *(bohN-zhoor)* — Morning / Hello
- **Yanis l'a posé** *(yah-nees lah poh-zay)* — Yanis put it down
- **il n'a pas choisi** *(eel nah pah shwah-zee)* — he didn't pick
- **Un pour toi, un pour moi** *(uhN poor twah, uhN poor mwah)* — One for you, one for me
- **Elle nous la donne** *(el noo lah dun)* — She's giving it to us
- **Je ne sais pas** *(zhuh nuh seh pah)* — I don't know
- **Tu te souviens ?** *(tew tuh soo-vyaN)* — Do you remember?
- **laisser les deux portes ouvertes** *(leh-say lay duh port oo-vairt)* — leave both doors open
- **ce serait notre salon** *(suh suh-reh noh-truh sah-lohN)* — it would be our living room
- **j'ai trouvé chaussure à mon pied** *(zhay troo-vay shoh-sewr ah mohN pyay)* — I've found my perfect match

Notice: Stressed pronouns: à nous, pour toi, pour moi

Gabriel says « Je crois que c'est à nous » and Zoé « Un pour toi, un pour moi ». After à, pour, avec and other prepositions, use the stressed pronouns moi, toi, lui, elle, nous, vous. Gabriel's line has changed over the series: « c'est à vous » (episode 1), « c'est à toi » (episode 15), « c'est à nous ».

See the table: Grammar tables, Stressed pronouns: moi, toi...

Questions

Episode 1 · Le colis

1. Why does Gabriel knock on Zoé's door?
   a. He has lost his keys
   b. He wants to borrow a candle
   c. Her parcel came to his door
   d. The lift is broken
2. What time does Gabriel go to bed?
   a. At half past nine
   b. At nine o'clock
   c. At six o'clock
   d. At two in the morning
3. What surprises Zoé at the end?
   a. Gabriel is from Marseille
   b. Gabriel plays the drums
   c. The parcel is not hers
   d. They have the same surname
4. What does Zoé say when Gabriel complains about the time?
   a. Bonne nuit, voisin !
   b. Et alors ? Neuf heures, c'est tôt !
   c. Il est très lourd.
   d. Pardon, monsieur. Je suis désolée.

Episode 2 · Le petit mot

1. Why is Zoé angry?
   a. Gabriel left her a note about the noise
   b. Gabriel opened her parcel
   c. Gabriel woke her at six
   d. Her drum is broken
2. Why does Gabriel complain about the drum?
   a. He can't sleep or work
   b. He has a headache
   c. He hates Marseille
   d. He wants to play too
3. What time do they agree on?
   a. Eleven o'clock
   b. Half past seven
   c. Half past ten
   d. Ten o'clock
4. How does Zoé accept the deal?
   a. Je suis en colère.
   b. Le silence aussi.
   c. Marché conclu !
   d. Onze heures.

Episode 3 · La guerre des petits mots

1. What is Gabriel doing to Zoé's notes?
   a. Correcting her mistakes in red
   b. Reading them to the concierge
   c. Throwing them away
   d. Writing a reply in green
2. How many mistakes does Gabriel find?
   a. None at all
   b. Six, in three words
   c. Three, in six words
   d. Two, in ten words
3. How do they end the evening?
   a. They call the concierge
   b. They slam their doors
   c. They swap notes by hand
   d. They take every note off the doors
4. Which line uses the expression du jour?
   a. Ah bon ? Et qui est le chien ?
   b. Encore vous !
   c. Un peu. C'est mon métier.
   d. Vous ! Vous grognez tout le temps.

Episode 4 · Le livreur

1. Why do the parcels go to the wrong door?
   a. The lift is always broken
   b. There are two Garniers on the sixth floor
   c. Yanis is new in Paris
   d. Zoé gives the wrong address
2. What are Gabriel's parcels like?
   a. Big and soft
   b. Long tubes
   c. Round and noisy
   d. Tiny and very heavy
3. How many parcels does Yanis have this morning?
   a. Fifteen
   b. Fifty
   c. Five
   d. Six
4. What does Yanis say about the doors?
   a. Je choisis une porte. Et c'est toujours la mauvaise !
   b. Je donne ma langue au chat.
   c. La porte verte, c'est moi.
   d. Pas le temps !

Episode 5 · La panne

1. Why does Zoé knock on Gabriel's door?
   a. Her drum is too loud
   b. She has his parcel
   c. She wants to borrow some tea
   d. There's a power cut and she has no candle
2. What is Gabriel's job?
   a. He repairs music boxes
   b. He repairs phones
   c. He sells candles
   d. He teaches music
3. What does Zoé ask Gabriel to call her?
   a. Madame
   b. Madame Garnier
   c. Voisine
   d. Zoé
4. How does Gabriel reassure Zoé?
   a. Il n'y a pas de lumière !
   b. Ne vous inquiétez pas.
   c. Pas de tambour.
   d. Vous n'aimez pas la musique !

Episode 6 · Le colis ouvert

1. What did Zoé do by mistake?
   a. She broke Gabriel's music box
   b. She lost Gabriel's keys
   c. She opened Gabriel's parcel
   d. She threw away Gabriel's notes
2. What was in the parcel?
   a. A tiny music box
   b. Candles
   c. Flower seeds
   d. Two hundred orange earplugs
3. Why did Zoé open it?
   a. It had her first name on it
   b. She thought it was gold
   c. She was waiting for seeds in the same paper
   d. Yanis told her to
4. What does Gabriel answer to Zoé's apology?
   a. Deux cents, c'est moins cher.
   b. J'ai mis les pieds dans le plat.
   c. Vous avez ouvert mon colis ?
   d. Ça ne fait rien.

Episode 7 · Le dîner

1. What is Gabriel wearing for dinner?
   a. A gold jacket
   b. A suit and a tie
   c. Dungarees
   d. His slippers and cardigan
2. How many chillies are in Zoé's chili?
   a. None
   b. Six
   c. Ten
   d. Two
3. What does Gabriel suggest at the end?
   a. He will cook next Saturday at his place
   b. They go to a restaurant
   c. They never eat chili again
   d. Zoé makes soup next time
4. What does Zoé answer when Gabriel says sorry for being early?
   a. Asseyez-vous.
   b. Le dîner est raté.
   c. Pas de souci, Gabriel !
   d. Seulement six !

Episode 8 · Six étages

1. What does Zoé propose on the stairs?
   a. That they call Fatou
   b. That they leave the sack downstairs
   c. That they say tu to each other
   d. That they stop for lunch
2. How heavy is Zoé's sack of soil?
   a. Six kilos
   b. Thirteen kilos
   c. Thirty kilos
   d. Twenty kilos
3. What does Gabriel say instead of "Tu es géniale"?
   a. That she's early
   b. That she's strong
   c. That she's stubborn
   d. That she's tired
4. How does Zoé thank Gabriel at the top?
   a. Je n'ai pas l'habitude.
   b. Je vais apporter le dessert.
   c. Merci pour le coup de main, Gabriel.
   d. On porte le sac à deux ?

Episode 9 · Le tambour du mercredi

1. Why is the noise louder on Wednesdays?
   a. Fatou plays the radio
   b. Monsieur Perrot repairs his flat
   c. Zoé gives free lessons to the children
   d. Zoé's band rehearses
2. For how long has Zoé given these lessons?
   a. For ten years
   b. For two years
   c. Since Gabriel arrived
   d. Since last week
3. What does Gabriel decide to do on the thirteenth?
   a. Buy more earplugs
   b. Go and listen to Zoé play in the park
   c. Move to another building
   d. Repair Fatou's radio
4. What does Fatou say about herself?
   a. Avec une cravate, monsieur Gabriel ?
   b. Elle a le cœur sur la main.
   c. Moi, je ne dis rien… mais je vois tout.
   d. Tout le monde s'est plaint, au début.

Episode 10 · Le trac

1. How many times has Zoé played in public?
   a. A hundred times
   b. Never
   c. Ten times
   d. Twice
2. What does Gabriel give her?
   a. A cup of tea
   b. A new drumstick
   c. A pair of earplugs
   d. A small music box he repaired
3. What happened to the earplugs?
   a. Adam took them
   b. Gabriel has them in his pocket
   c. Gabriel threw them away on Wednesday
   d. Zoé gave them to Fatou
4. How does Zoé feel before going on stage?
   a. C'est génial !
   b. J'ai le trac.
   c. Mon cœur va moins vite.
   d. Tu as été formidable.

Episode 11 · La boîte cassée

1. Whose box is on the high shelf?
   a. A collector's
   b. Fatou's
   c. Gabriel's grandmother's
   d. Zoé's mother's
2. How old was Gabriel when he broke the box?
   a. Fifteen
   b. Six
   c. Ten
   d. Twenty
3. What does Zoé do when Gabriel winds the box?
   a. She plays the drum
   b. She repairs the comb
   c. She sings the missing note
   d. She turns off the lamp
4. Why doesn't Gabriel repair the box?
   a. Cette boîte est très fragile.
   b. Elle ne tourne pas rond.
   c. J'ai peur de la casser encore.
   d. Le soir, Mamie chantait avec elle.

Episode 12 · Comme des sardines

1. How many people lived in Zoé's flat in Marseille?
   a. Five
   b. Nine
   c. Six
   d. Three
2. Why did Zoé bang on saucepans?
   a. Her brothers were asleep
   b. Her mother asked her to
   c. Nobody listened to her
   d. She was learning to cook
3. What was Gabriel's childhood home like?
   a. Full of drums
   b. Full of plants
   c. Very loud, like Zoé's
   d. Very quiet: everyone whispered
4. Which line uses the expression du jour?
   a. On chuchotait.
   b. On était serrés comme des sardines !
   c. Une plante, ce n'est pas une montre.
   d. Ça me plaît.

Episode 13 · La valise verte

1. What did Zoé see on Monday night?
   a. Fatou crying on the stairs
   b. Gabriel hugging a woman with a green suitcase
   c. Gabriel leaving with a suitcase
   d. Yanis delivering flowers
2. What colour was the woman's suitcase?
   a. Blue
   b. Green
   c. Red
   d. Yellow
3. What does Yanis advise Zoé to do?
   a. Ask Gabriel
   b. Forget Gabriel
   c. Leave him a note
   d. Move out
4. What does Yanis tell Zoé?
   a. Elle riait fort.
   b. Je l'ai vue, Yanis !
   c. Madame Zoé, vous vous faites un film !
   d. Petit et lourd, comme toujours.

Episode 14 · La sœur

1. What does Hélène find in the blue tin?
   a. All of Zoé's yellow notes, in order
   b. Old photos of Mamie Jeanne
   c. Spare parts for music boxes
   d. Train tickets
2. Why was Zoé cold with Gabriel, according to Hélène?
   a. Gabriel forgot their dinner
   b. Her drum was too loud
   c. She is angry about the earplugs
   d. She saw them hug and thinks Hélène is his fiancée
3. When did Zoé see them?
   a. On Monday night, on the landing
   b. On Saturday at dinner
   c. On Sunday in the park
   d. Yesterday in the courtyard
4. How does Gabriel ask his sister's opinion?
   a. Ce n'est rien.
   b. Dans l'ordre.
   c. Mais tu es ma sœur !
   d. Pourquoi, à ton avis ?

Episode 15 · Les pendules à l'heure

1. Why has Zoé been cold since Monday?
   a. Gabriel complained about her drums
   b. Gabriel forgot her parcel
   c. Her concert went badly
   d. She thought the woman she saw was Gabriel's girlfriend
2. Who was the woman?
   a. A music-box collector
   b. A new neighbour
   c. His cousin from Besançon
   d. Hélène, Gabriel's sister
3. What is Hélène's job?
   a. She drives TGV trains
   b. She is a delivery rider
   c. She repairs music boxes
   d. She teaches drums
4. How does Zoé invite Gabriel?
   a. Demain soir, je fais un chili. Ça te dit ?
   b. Encore toi !
   c. Je me faisais un film.
   d. Tu peux le poser là.

Episode 16 · La lettre

1. What will the building vote on?
   a. Banning musical instruments in the flats
   b. Hiring a new concierge
   c. Painting the landing
   d. Repairing the lift
2. Where could Zoé move?
   a. Back to Marseille
   b. To a studio with a garage in Montreuil
   c. To Besançon
   d. To the fifth floor
3. What does Gabriel finally say about the landing?
   a. It needs new tiles
   b. It's too noisy
   c. It's too small for two
   d. Without Zoé it would be far too quiet
4. Which line uses the expression du jour?
   a. Ce serait dommage… pour l'immeuble.
   b. Je pourrais partir.
   c. Je vais trouver une idée.
   d. Tu te souviens ?

Episode 17 · La cave

1. How did Fatou meet her husband?
   a. She was his concierge
   b. The postman kept putting his letters in her box
   c. They met at a concert
   d. They worked at the same bus company
2. How long have Fatou and Moussa been married?
   a. Fifteen years
   b. Forty years
   c. Thirty-five years
   d. Twenty-five years
3. What is Gabriel's idea?
   a. To buy Zoé a garage
   b. To give Monsieur Perrot earplugs
   c. To move to Montreuil with her
   d. To turn the old cellar into a music room
4. What does Fatou advise Gabriel?
   a. Asseyez-vous.
   b. Il y a la vieille cave.
   c. Les erreurs de facteur, ça marche.
   d. Vous devriez lui dire ce que vous ressentez.

Episode 18 · La réunion

1. What did Gabriel do at the meeting?
   a. He asked Fatou to speak for him
   b. He stayed at home
   c. He stood up and defended Zoé's music
   d. He voted against the drums
2. Why did Monsieur Perrot vote yes?
   a. Fatou asked him to
   b. He is moving out
   c. He likes loud music
   d. His grandson would like to learn the drums
3. When could they start building the music room?
   a. Next month
   b. On Saturday
   c. On Wednesday
   d. Tomorrow morning
4. How does Zoé react to the vote?
   a. Je n'en reviens pas !
   b. La cave.
   c. Le noir, encore !
   d. Tu sais quoi ?

Episode 19 · La note qui manque

1. What was in the parcel from the Jura?
   a. A drum for Zoé
   b. A letter from Hélène
   c. A new comb for Mamie Jeanne's music box
   d. A new music box
2. How did Zoé get the comb?
   a. Fatou had one in the cellar
   b. She called Hélène, who called Mamie Jeanne
   c. She ordered it from a shop
   d. Yanis found it
3. Since when has Zoé had feelings for Gabriel?
   a. Since the candle in the power cut
   b. Since the concert
   c. Since the first dinner
   d. Since the meeting
4. What does Gabriel say when he is afraid?
   a. Alors il est pour toi.
   b. C'est moi qui te le dis.
   c. Depuis le tambour.
   d. Et si je la casse encore ?

Episode 20 · Le bon colis

1. Where did Yanis leave the parcel?
   a. At the green door
   b. At the navy door
   c. In the middle of the landing, between the two doors
   d. With Fatou in the loge
2. Who sent the parcel?
   a. Fatou
   b. Hélène
   c. Mamie Jeanne
   d. Monsieur Perrot
3. What does Zoé suggest for the doors?
   a. Leave both doors open
   b. Paint them the same colour
   c. Put their names on them
   d. Swap flats
4. What is the last line of the story?
   a. Et elle joue quoi ?
   b. Je crois que c'est à nous.
   c. La mauvaise porte, c'était la bonne.
   d. Tu te souviens ?

Answer key

1.1 c) Her parcel came to his door
1.2 a) At half past nine
1.3 d) They have the same surname
1.4 b) Et alors ? Neuf heures, c'est tôt !
2.1 a) Gabriel left her a note about the noise
2.2 a) He can't sleep or work
2.3 c) Half past ten
2.4 c) Marché conclu !
3.1 a) Correcting her mistakes in red
3.2 c) Three, in six words
3.3 c) They swap notes by hand
3.4 a) Ah bon ? Et qui est le chien ?
4.1 b) There are two Garniers on the sixth floor
4.2 d) Tiny and very heavy
4.3 a) Fifteen
4.4 a) Je choisis une porte. Et c'est toujours la mauvaise !
5.1 d) There's a power cut and she has no candle
5.2 a) He repairs music boxes
5.3 d) Zoé
5.4 b) Ne vous inquiétez pas.
6.1 c) She opened Gabriel's parcel
6.2 d) Two hundred orange earplugs
6.3 c) She was waiting for seeds in the same paper
6.4 d) Ça ne fait rien.
7.1 b) A suit and a tie
7.2 b) Six
7.3 a) He will cook next Saturday at his place
7.4 c) Pas de souci, Gabriel !
8.1 c) That they say tu to each other
8.2 c) Thirty kilos
8.3 c) That she's stubborn
8.4 c) Merci pour le coup de main, Gabriel.
9.1 c) Zoé gives free lessons to the children
9.2 b) For two years
9.3 b) Go and listen to Zoé play in the park
9.4 c) Moi, je ne dis rien… mais je vois tout.
10.1 a) A hundred times
10.2 d) A small music box he repaired
10.3 c) Gabriel threw them away on Wednesday
10.4 b) J'ai le trac.
11.1 c) Gabriel's grandmother's
11.2 c) Ten
11.3 c) She sings the missing note
11.4 c) J'ai peur de la casser encore.
12.1 b) Nine
12.2 c) Nobody listened to her
12.3 d) Very quiet: everyone whispered
12.4 b) On était serrés comme des sardines !
13.1 b) Gabriel hugging a woman with a green suitcase
13.2 b) Green
13.3 a) Ask Gabriel
13.4 c) Madame Zoé, vous vous faites un film !
14.1 a) All of Zoé's yellow notes, in order
14.2 d) She saw them hug and thinks Hélène is his fiancée
14.3 a) On Monday night, on the landing
14.4 d) Pourquoi, à ton avis ?
15.1 d) She thought the woman she saw was Gabriel's girlfriend
15.2 d) Hélène, Gabriel's sister
15.3 a) She drives TGV trains
15.4 a) Demain soir, je fais un chili. Ça te dit ?
16.1 a) Banning musical instruments in the flats
16.2 b) To a studio with a garage in Montreuil
16.3 d) Without Zoé it would be far too quiet
16.4 a) Ce serait dommage… pour l'immeuble.
17.1 b) The postman kept putting his letters in her box
17.2 c) Thirty-five years
17.3 d) To turn the old cellar into a music room
17.4 d) Vous devriez lui dire ce que vous ressentez.
18.1 c) He stood up and defended Zoé's music
18.2 d) His grandson would like to learn the drums
18.3 b) On Saturday
18.4 a) Je n'en reviens pas !
19.1 c) A new comb for Mamie Jeanne's music box
19.2 b) She called Hélène, who called Mamie Jeanne
19.3 a) Since the candle in the power cut
19.4 d) Et si je la casse encore ?
20.1 c) In the middle of the landing, between the two doors
20.2 c) Mamie Jeanne
20.3 a) Leave both doors open
20.4 c) La mauvaise porte, c'était la bonne.

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